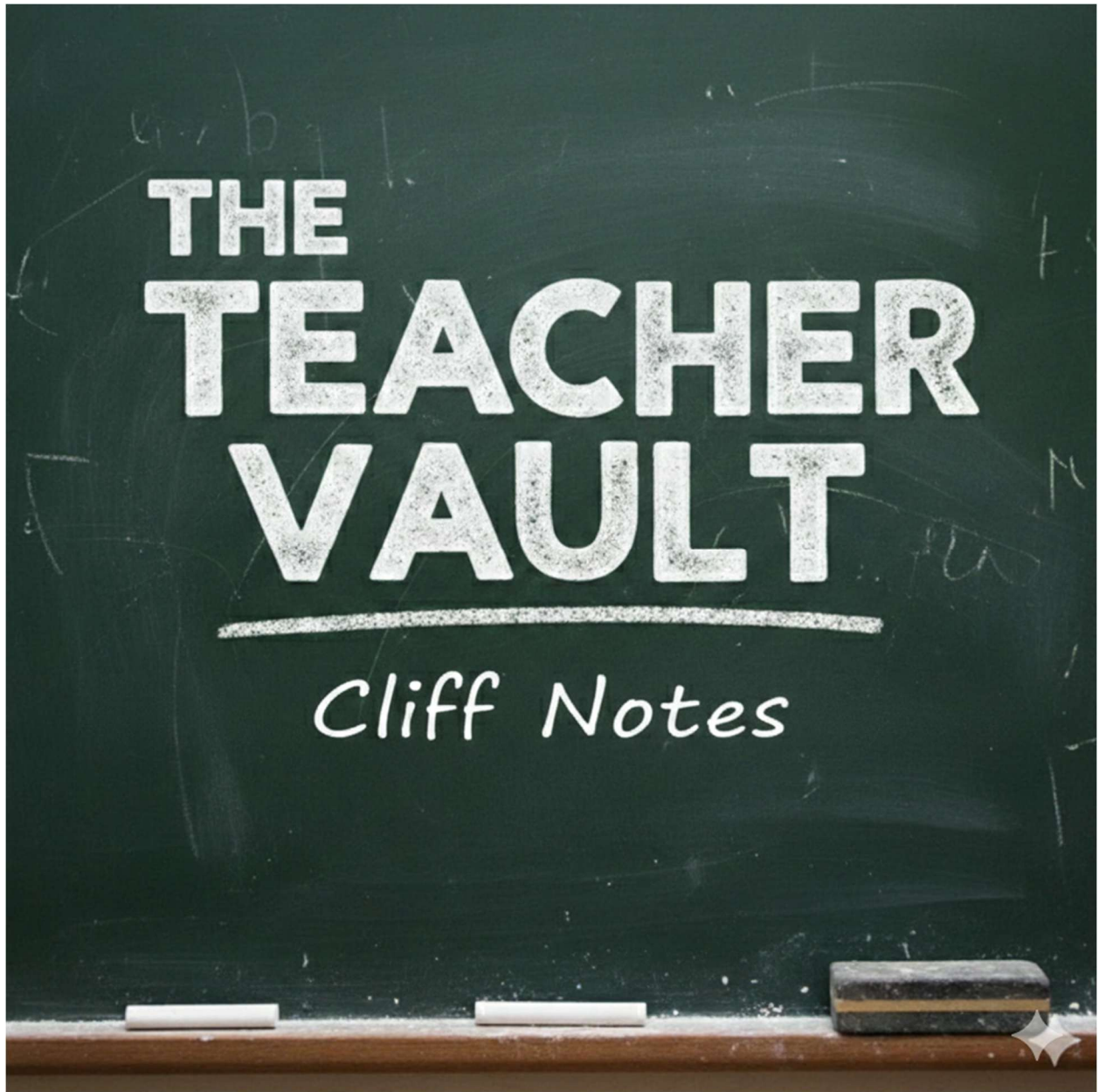


An Inspector Calls

CLIFF NOTES



An Inspector Calls

CLIFF NOTES

Context (VERY exam important)

- Written in **1945**
- Set in **1912**
- Post-WWII Britain
- Socialist message
- Critique of capitalism
- Dramatic irony (audience knows Titanic + WWI are coming)

Priestley = strong belief in **social responsibility**

Plot Summary (Act by Act)

Act 1

- Engagement party for Sheila & Gerald
- Mr Birling makes arrogant capitalist speech
- Inspector Goole arrives
- Eva Smith fired by Birling
- Sheila had Eva sacked from Milwards
- Sheila begins to accept guilt

Act 2

- Gerald had affair with Eva (Daisy Renton)
- Mrs Birling refused charity help
- She blames the father of Eva's baby

Act 3

- Eric is revealed as the father
 - He stole money
 - Inspector leaves
 - They discover no inspector exists
 - Phone rings: real inspector on the way
-

An Inspector Calls

CLIFF NOTES

Main Characters (Quick Exam Focus)

Mr Birling

- Capitalist
- “A man has to mind his own business”
- Dramatic irony makes him look foolish
- Represents selfish upper class

Sheila

- Starts naive
- Develops moral awareness
- Represents hope for change

Gerald

- Charming but self-serving
- Learns nothing

Mrs Birling

- Cold
- Hypocritical
- Refuses responsibility

Eric

- Immature
- Exploits Eva
- Shows guilt and growth

Inspector Goole

- Moral force
- Possibly supernatural
- Symbol of conscience
- Voice of Priestley

An Inspector Calls

CLIFF NOTES

Themes (High-Grade Focus)

◆ Social Responsibility

“We are members of one body”

◆ Class

Upper class exploit working class

◆ Gender

Women economically vulnerable

◆ Generational Divide

Young accept blame

Older refuse responsibility

◆ Capitalism vs Socialism

Central political message

Key Quotes to Memorise

- “Unsinkable, absolutely unsinkable” (dramatic irony)
 - “Public men, Mr Birling, have responsibilities”
 - “We are members of one body”
 - “You’re beginning to pretend now that nothing’s really happened”
 - “If men will not learn that lesson...”
-

An Inspector Calls

CLIFF NOTES

Exam Structure Reminder (GCSE)

Typical question:

How does Priestley present responsibility in *An Inspector Calls*?

Structure:

1. Clear argument
 2. Analyse language
 3. Link to context
 4. Explore writer's intention
-

★ Grade 8–9 Insight

- Inspector = morality play figure
- Cyclical ending = lesson not learned
- Time structure suggests inevitability
- Eva = symbol of working class suffering